Browser troubleshooting: crashes, slowness and certificate errors

Article KB0010061 | Owner: Service Desk L1 | Subcategory: Browser issues | Applies to: Windows 11 23H2/24H2 on Dell Latitude 5440/7440, Lenovo ThinkPad T14/X1 Carbon, HP EliteBook 840, macOS 14/15 on MacBook Pro/Air, Google Chrome, Microsoft Edge, Mozilla Firefox (versions managed via Intune Company Portal)

Summary

This article helps users and service-desk agents diagnose and resolve common browser problems such as crashes, extreme slowness, certificate warnings, and unwanted pop-ups or redirects. It provides a quick self-help checklist, a detailed agent-focused troubleshooting flow, and guidance on when to escalate to specialist teams. Following the steps restores normal browsing while staying within Acme Global's IT policies.

Symptoms

- Chrome fails to open, crashes immediately, or shows a blank window
- Edge or Chrome responds slowly; page loads exceed 10-15 seconds
- Certificate error messages such as NET::ERR_CERT_DATE_INVALID, ERR_CERT_AUTHORITY_INVALID, or SEC_ERROR_EXPIRED_ISSUER_CERTIFICATE
- Unexpected pop-ups, new tabs opening to advertising or unfamiliar sites
- Browser reports 'Your connection is not private' or warns about an untrusted certificate

Common causes

- Corrupted browser cache, cookies, or user profile
- System date/time set incorrectly, causing certificate validation failures
- Out-of-date browser version or missing security updates
- Malicious or poorly behaved extensions/adware injecting ads or redirects
- Conflicting security software (e.g., third-party AV) blocking browser processes
- Group Policy or Intune configuration that restricts certain features
- Expired or untrusted root certificates in the local machine store

Initial checks

Before diving into fixes, verify a few basic items that often explain the behaviour. Confirm that the device is connected to the corporate network (VPN or Wi-Fi ACME-Corp) and that the system clock shows the correct IST time. Ensure no other application is consuming excessive CPU or RAM (check Task Manager). Finally, note whether the issue affects all browsers or only a specific one, as this helps isolate profile- versus system-wide causes.

Self-help procedure (user)

Follow these steps to restore normal browser performance. Each step can be completed without admin rights; if a step requires elevation, the user will be prompted for their PIN or password.

1. Close all browser windows and end any lingering processes via Task Manager (look for chrome.exe, msedge.exe, firefox.exe).
2. Open the browser's Settings -> Privacy and security -> Clear browsing data. Choose 'All time', tick Cached images and files, Cookies and other site data, then click Clear data.
3. Reset the browser to its default settings: Settings -> Reset and clean up -> Restore settings to their original defaults -> Reset settings.
4. Verify the system date and time: right-click the clock -> Adjust date/time -> Set time automatically enabled; if incorrect, enable it or manually set the correct IST time.
5. Review installed extensions: open the extensions page, disable any unfamiliar or recently added items, then remove them completely.
6. Run a quick Microsoft Defender scan: open Windows Security -> Virus & threat protection -> Quick scan, or on macOS run a built-in malware scan via Intune Company Portal if available.
7. Restart the computer, launch the browser again, and test a known internal site (e.g., https://it.acme.example) to confirm the issue is resolved.

Service-desk procedure

When the self-help steps do not resolve the ticket, agents should perform a deeper investigation while adhering to Acme Global's change-management and security policies.

1. Confirm the user's device is compliant in Intune (check Device compliance status; non-compliant devices may have restricted browser access).
2. If non-compliant, guide the user to enroll/re-enroll the device via Company Portal or remediate the reported compliance issue (e.g., missing BitLocker/FileVault encryption, pending OS updates).
3. Check for conflicting Group Policy or Intune App Protection Policies that may disable JavaScript, block certain sites, or force proxy settings; adjust or create an exception as needed.
4. Export and review the browser's logs (chrome://net-internals/#events for Chrome, edge://net-internals for Edge) to pinpoint certificate or network failures.
5. If certificate errors persist, verify the trusted root certificate store: run certmgr.msc -> Trusted Root Certification Authorities and ensure the DigiCert, Sectigo, and Microsoft roots are present and not expired; re-deploy missing certificates via Intune if necessary.
6. Should the profile be corrupted beyond repair, back up bookmarks/passwords (if allowed) then uninstall the browser via Company Portal and reinstall the latest approved version.
7. After each action, ask the user to retest and document the outcome in the ticket.

Verification

After applying any fix, verify that the browser behaves normally and that no residual issues remain. Open several internal and external sites (e.g., https://it.acme.example, https://outlook.office.com, a public news site) and confirm page load times are under three seconds. Check that no certificate warnings appear and that pop-up blockers are active. Finally, run the Microsoft Defender quick scan again to ensure no malware was introduced during troubleshooting.

Additional tips and prevention

Encourage users to keep their browsers up to date through the Company Portal, as updates are pushed monthly alongside Patch Tuesday. Advise against installing extensions from unverified sources; only use those published in the Microsoft Store or Chrome Web Store with a verified publisher. Remind users to report any suspicious pop-ups or redirects immediately via the Outlook "Report phishing" button or the Teams IT Help channel so the Security Operations team can investigate.

When to escalate

If the browser continues to crash, show certificate errors, or exhibit malicious behaviour after the service-desk procedure has been completed, escalate to the Identity & Access Management team for certificate-or-authentication issues, or to the Security Operations team for suspected malware/adware. Include in the escalation: device name, OS version, browser version, Intune compliance status, relevant error messages (exact text), steps already taken, and any logs or screenshots collected.

Keywords: browser crash, Chrome not opening, Edge slow, certificate error, NET_ERR_CERT_DATE_INVALID, ERR_CERT_AUTHORITY_INVALID, pop-up redirect, malicious extension, clear cache, reset browser settings, system date time, Intune compliance, Defender scan, Company Portal